The world wars of 1914–18 and 1939–45 were almost certainly the most costly conflicts ever fought. Their combined death toll may have exceeded 80 million. The massive number of casualties was the result of "total war", the devotion of the entire resources of modern industrial states to warfare and the exploitation of every possible means of attacking the enemy without limit or scruple, including the systematic massacre of civilians and the destruction of cities. The typical fighting man in these wars of mass destruction was a civilian hastily thrust into uniform through conscription or the large-scale recruitment of volunteers.

Whatever the political system under which he served, the civilian was in principle a citizen-soldier, fighting for the society to which he belonged, and motivated primarily by feelings of patriotism. A state that could no longer count on the active support of the mass of its people for the war effort – as was the case for Tsarist Russia by 1917 – was doomed.

OVERWHELMING FIREPOWER

In the line-up of powers, the two world conflicts were remarkably similar. In both, Germany fought Britain, France, Russia, and the United States, although the struggle in Asia and the Pacific between Japan and the United States, Britain, and China added an extra dimension to World War II. But the nature of the fighting in the two wars was strikingly different. From the outset of World War I the

Men and machines
Soviet soldiers advance alongside a T-34 tank. The resources – both human and industrial – that the Soviet Union could call on in World War II brought victory, but at appalling cost.







